

Raphael

Like Leonardo and Michelangelo, Raphael (1483–1520) is one of an elite group of artists recognized by just his first name. For over 500 years his art has been considered by many as the embodiment of classical harmony. During his short life he was hugely productive, running an extremely large workshop and becoming the favoured painter and architect at the papal court.

Born Raffaello Sanzio in Urbino, Italy, Raphael learned painting techniques and humanistic principles from his father, Giovanni Santi, painter for the Duke of Urbino, and from Perugino. His lyrical and sculptural style pioneered a more human approach to devotional images – tender Madonna and Child groups were among the first paintings of the subject to display such lifelike and vulnerable gestures and expressions. Whether Bible stories, myths or portraits, he injected a sense of beauty and realism into all his work. From 1504 to 1507, he worked in Florence, then from 1509 to 1511 in Rome, where he painted Vatican frescoes including *The School of Athens*. In 1514, he became the Pope's chief architect.



Raphael, *The Madonna of the Chair*, 1513–4